MEDICATION MANAGEMENT FOR CAREGIVERS

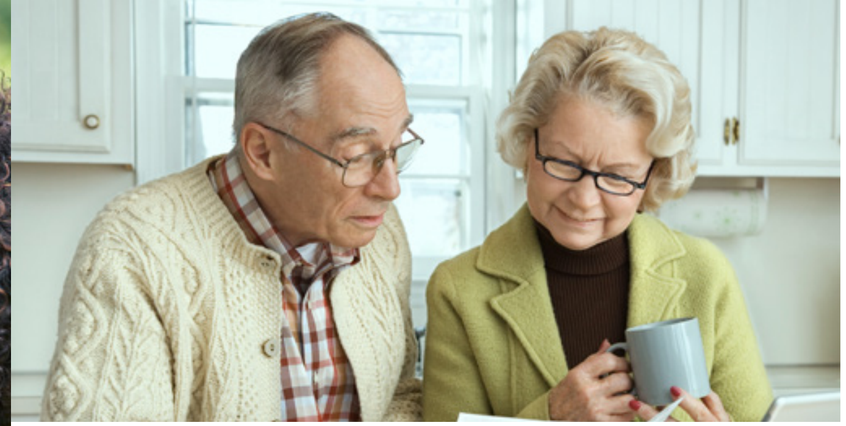
An ebook from:

Fidelity & Guaranty Life®

DO YOUR PARENTS OR OTHER FRIENDS NEED YOUR ASSISTANCE?

Have you seen evidence of declining health? Has their medication use or the amount of medication they take increased?

The first step to take is to get a solid understanding of their current medication use, and what that medication is.



HOW DO I START?

The first step is to document your knowledge and your parent's knowledge of any allergies and intolerances. Allergies are hypersensitivity reactions to medication like rashes or itching. It can also be anaphylactic reactions such as trouble breathing, swelling tongue or a change in heart rhythm. These reactions can be life threatening and need to be well documented with all healthcare providers and pharmacies. Intolerances are medications that make you sick to your stomach, have intolerable side effects, or just don't work for a person. Accurate documentation of all of these is important for all prescribers and pharmacists. It helps them make better healthcare decisions for your parent.

44% of men and 57% of women older than age 65 take five or more medications per week.

12%

About 12% of both men and women take 10 or more medications per week.

12 Medication Management Tips That May Save Your Life - Senior Living Blog

http://www.aplaceformom.com/blog/1-27-2014-medication-management-tips/

HOW DO I GET A LIST OF MY PARENT'S MEDICATIONS?

Look at each medication bottle and write the instructions on the label. Sit down and talk to you parents about how and when they take the medication. Ask them what time of day they take it and if they take it with food or on an empty stomach. Ask them how they feel after they take it – do they feel fine or do they have suspected side affects? Also, find out if they take the medication on a daily basis or if they just take it when needed.

Another important thing to find out is which type of vitamins or supplements, if any, they take. These aren't typically thought of as medications, but they may affect other medications they take. Even though they're not "typical" medications, they're important for your parent's healthcare team to know about as they evaluate your parent's care. Also, include any herbal, holistic, or 'natural' therapies as well any over-the-counter medication use. You will need to find out when and why your parent's take these and the frequency.

This level of detail allows healthcare providers to thoroughly evaluate medication use and assure your parent is on the safest, more beneficial regimen.

CAN THEIR PHARMACY HELP?

To make sure you have included all medications on the list, contact your parent's pharmacy. You can take your list to the pharmacist or ask for a printout of all prescriptions filled in the last year. Ask the pharmacist for any insights about the current regimen or medications tried in the past. The pharmacist can often tell you if they've been refilling their prescriptions on a routine basis, or if there have been gaps, inconsistencies or recent regime changes. The pharmacist will also have notes about your parent's medication usage and any known allergies.

WHY SHOULD YOU SHARE THE PHARMACY LIST?

Share your list with your parent's primary care physician and all specialists. Gaps in information between providers are not uncommon. Sharing your list with all providers will help you and all providers get a full grasp of all medications your parent's take. While exchanging this information with providers, also cross check your list of allergies and intolerances. This will help make sure that all key decision-makers are working from the same complete set of information.

Prescription medicines are vital to many seniors' lives. They cannot afford to forget their medicines too many days in a row... or to take too many the next day. Running out or not being able to find them can also be a huge issue.

Concierge Care - 5 Ways to Ensure that Your Elderly Parents are Taking their Medications
http://www.conciergecarefl.com/5-ways-to-ensure-that-your-elderly-parents-are-taking-their-medications/

WHAT ARE OTHER IMPORTANT MEDICATION-RELATED INFORMATION?

TOBACCO USE

Does your parent smoke? Have they ever smoked? Any history or current use of smoking, including daily amount, is important information to know. Tobacco use of any kind is related to risks for some medical conditions, management of some medical conditions, and even dosing of some medications. Exposure to tobacco can also result in the need for a higher or lower dose of some medications.

Tackling medication issues is a "tough subject."

How to Help Aging Parents Manage Medications - US News and World Reports
http://health.usnews.com/health-news/patient-advice/slideshows/how-to-help-aging-parents-manage-medications

ALCOHOL

Similar to tobacco, current use, former use, and quantities are important information about alcohol use. Include the types of alcohol consumed. As examples, if your parent has diabetes, the amount of carbohydrates and sugars in various alcohol drinks can be important. If your parent is at an increased risk of falling, quantities and timing of alcohol consumption are important factors in risk reduction. Similar to tobacco, alcohol can interact with some medications resulting in the need for a dose adjustment or use of an alternative medication.

DRUG USE

Include in the current medication list any recreational drug use. This may be common family knowledge, or it could be a difficult conversation to have with a parent. Today's 65-80 year olds were in their teens and 20's in the 1960's and 1970's, an era known for counterculture trends. The recreational drug industry took off during this era, and for many older adults, use has continued. As with prescription medications, recreational drug use can increase risk of some medical conditions, interact with other medications, and increase risk of events such as falls or heart attacks. It is important that the medical team know of such use.

HOW DO I MANAGE MEDICATION USE IN THE HOME?

Knowing when to take medications at the right time and at the right dose can be overwhelming for the elderly. For some adults, inability to manage this is a sign that they may need assistance. Do your parents sometimes forget to take their medication? Do they sometimes take their medication, but then forget that they've taken it? Or maybe they take their medication twice because they've forgotten? It's easy for medication regimens to become confusing. For instance, they switch the frequency of medication A with medication B and neither is taken properly.

Keep a list of all prescription numbers and the medications they reference. It will make it easier to talk to pharmacists and physicians about medication management.

WHAT ARE SOME SIMPLE SOLUTIONS?

A simple and inexpensive option for managing medications is the use of pillboxes. These allow your parent, or you, to organize the medications for a full week. Boxes are available for once daily dosing up to four times daily dosing. There are two key advantages to this solution. One is overcoming the need to read each label every day. The medications are sorted and available at the appropriate times at the right doses. The second advantage is the reminder it provides. If your parent doesn't remember taking the medication, they can just look in the box and see if it's still there. This is also a very inexpensive solution.

WHAT ARE SOME MORE ADVANCED SOLUTIONS?

There are several tools on the market to assist with daily medication management. Depending on the difficult aspects of managing medications, there are devices to remind when it is time and some that keep the medication locked, then dispensed in the right quantity at the right time. There are also devises that track the time the medication is removed from the device and some that alert a family member when medication is not removed.

There are also services to prepackage medications. These services can package medications by time of day and day of the week. They can package an entire month at one time and then each dose can be removed so that it is portable.

Beyond devices, there are also in-home services available by phone or in person that can help administer medication. Many home health agencies have a-la-carte options to select the services needed for your parents. One of those options is to have a caregiver go to their home to administer the medication. The caregiver ensures that your parents take the medication properly. While there, they also can perform a quick wellness check on your parents. Other services have the option of calling your parents at certain times to remind them to take their medication and if necessary, how much.

MEDICATION STORAGE

Keeping medications in 1-2 key places in the home can help your parents remember to take it. When medications are scattered in different places it's difficult for the caregiver, or your parents to keep them straight.

Four places where you should NOT keep medications:

- **Bathroom medicine cabinet** – Surprising, but the steam and moisture from showers and baths can break down medications
- **Windowsill** – This area can get hot and break down medications
- **Near the stove or oven** – As above, heat and moisture can be bad for medication
- **Glove box/trunk** – Leaving medication in glove box or trunk for prolonged periods can expose it to extreme heat or cold

WHAT ARE SOME OTHER OPTIONS TO MANAGE MEDICATION?

Many pharmacies now offer the service to automatically refill prescriptions at certain times. This process synchronizes refills so medications are all due for renewal at the same time. This great service prevents multiple trips to the pharmacy and ensures that important medication refills on time.

Hint: Use one pharmacy. Most people have more than one doctor - using one pharmacy ensures all prescriptions are in one place. This means the pharmacist will be able to monitor the medications for interactions, allergy issues and other medication-related problems.

40%

The inability to take their medication unsupervised accounts for up to 40% of nursing home admissions.

Caring - Aging in Place Gadgets
https://www.caring.com/checklists/useful-gadgets-for-elderly

DOES YOUR PARENT HAVE MEDICATION-RELATED ISSUES?

Do you suspect that there are medication-related problems with your parent? If the prescribers and local pharmacist are not able to pinpoint the specific problem, a clinical pharmacist can provide a very comprehensive review of all medications, lab parameters, and medical conditions. This medication expertise and thorough analysis can often pinpoint and remedy problems that are not quickly apparent during regular medical visits. To resolve any problems identified, the clinical pharmacist will work closely with the rest of the healthcare team.

DO YOU WORRY ABOUT YOUR PARENT'S SAFETY?

When memory is declining, it is safest to keep all medication locked. This includes over-the-counter medications, vitamins, supplements and other substances. As your parents age they may become confused about their medications. They may forget to take them or take them too often. If you feel that your parents have reached this point, it may be time to think about hiring someone to administer their medications for them, if you are unable to help.

"Playing an active role in managing your parents' medications becomes even more necessary for their safety and health. Doing so will also help give you peace of mind."

6 Ways to Help your Older Parents Use Medications the Right Way and Prevent Problems - MUST for Seniors
http://www.mustforseniors.org/documents/must_6_ways_to_help.pdf

HOW DO I DISPOSE OF MEDICATION?

A key safety action to take now is to remove all outdated medications and any your parents no longer take. You should peel and shred the label from each medication bottle as it contains personal health information. The ideal way to dispose of the actual medication (if any remaining) is with a medication take-back program. With a medication take-back program, the pharmacy makes sure that the medication is disposed of properly. This Food and Drug Administration (FDA) website has links to help you find pharmacies in your area that participate in this Drug Enforcement Agency (DEA) program. Also, local police barracks often have kiosks located outside where you may discard unneeded medication.

FDA - How to Dispose of Unused Medicines
http://www.fda.gov/ForConsumers/ConsumerUpdates/ucm101653.htm

TAKEAWAY

As our parents age, it's important to have the critical conversations that will help in case there's a crisis. From financial records to computer passwords to tax records, medication management is another key factor in the "conversation". Medication management may seem like a small part of the overall caregiving issues that adult children have to face, but it's an important part of the big picture. You may face some resistance, but in the end, having your parent take the right medication at the right time is key to them living a long and healthy life!